



JAMAICA CONSTABULARY FORCE

Policy and Standard Operating Procedure on the Management of Sudden, and Unnatural Death and Post-mortems

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1.0 Introduction

Significant responsibility is placed on the Jamaica Constabulary Force (JCF) to investigate the sudden passing of individuals. The Police must establish how, when, where and by what means the individual died. The initial investigation involves visiting the scene of death; making observations and recording statements. The investigation is necessary for evidence purposes as also to assist the pathologist to understand the circumstances of the death should a post-mortem become necessary.

This Policy and Standard Operating Procedures incorporates publications in and subsequent amendments Force Order Nos. 3584, dated 2016-02-11 in 2016-02-18, and 2016-05-05, respectively is hereby republished with amendments to ‘Sudden Death where the deceased had a known medical condition’, for general information and strict compliance. sets out the minimum standards to be adhered to by all members of the JCF and Rural Police for the management of Sudden Deaths, Unnatural Deaths and Post Mortems. Any departure from these procedures will be viewed as a breach of discipline.

2.0 Purpose

The purpose of this Policy and Standard Operating Procedure (SOP), is to ensure that all members of the JCF, charged with the responsibility of investigating the circumstances of any sudden and, or unnatural death, follow the laid down investigative procedures in order to bring closure to the matter in a dignified, timely, transparent and professional manner.

It also places emphasis on the timely submission of data pertaining to the deceased so that the JCF can fulfill its obligations in the recording of vital statistics.

3.0 Scope

This Policy and Standard Operating Procedures on the Management of Sudden, and Unnatural Deaths and Post Mortems applies to all sworn and unsworn members of the JCF and covers deaths investigated by the police.

4.0 Abbreviations and Acronyms

IO	Investigating Officer
IFSLM	Institute of Forensic Science & Legal Medicine
SD1	Sudden Death Report Form
JCF	Jamaica Constabulary Force
LMU	Legal Medicine Unit
SOP	Standard Operation Procedures
PRDB	Planning, Research and Development Branch

5.0 Definitions

- 5.1 **Autopsy Requisition Form-** A form completed by the police and submitted to the Pathology Unit (Legal Medicine Unit) stating the circumstances and the reason for the police investigation of such death.
- 5.2 **First Responder:** Any member of the JCF or Rural Police who initially attends the scene **of any unnatural or sudden death.**
- 5.3 **Form D:** A specific form issued under hand by the Coroner of the parish upon the submission of the investigation report and post-mortem.
- 5.4 **Investigator:** Any member of the JCF and Rural Police who has been assigned to investigate into the circumstances which led to the sudden or unnatural death of any person in Jamaica.
- 5.5 **Pathologist:** Certified Medical Practitioner who performs autopsies that can be a means of determining death, or to give information as needed by criminal investigators to determine possible criminal involvement in a person's death.
- 5.6 **Sudden death:** An instant unexpected death. It is also a death that occurs with the onset of symptoms which results in the abrupt change in a person's stable clinical state; where other unnatural causes have been ruled out such as accident, suicide, injury and poison.
- 5.7 **Unnatural death:** (a) A death caused by external cause such as injury, or poisoning and which includes death due to intentional injury such as homicide, suicide, and death caused by unintentional injuries. (b) All human deaths not properly describable as death by natural causes.
- 5.8 **Unidentified body:** A body for which there is no verifiable means of determining name, age, or place of residence.

6.0 Responsibilities

The following summarizes key roles and responsibilities:

6.1 Divisional Commander

The Divisional Commander shall on receipt of a sudden death report, cause an entry to be made in the **Divisional Sudden Death Register and the information extracted and sent to the Planning, Research and Development Branch Statistics and Information Management Unit (SIMU) no later than the 8th day of each succeeding month.** The information should be sent on the prescribed form attached at Appendix 1 – Sudden Death Report Form (SD1). For divisions

with internet connection the information should be sent in excel format to statistics@jcf.gov.jm.

6.5 The Divisional Administrative Officer

6.5.1 Vet all Autopsy Requisition Form and make a formal request for post-mortem to the Director of the Pathology Unit (Legal Medicine Unit - LMU) through email: **autopsydrj@gmail.com** or **Forensiclab@jcf.gov.jm** or Fax 977-0234. This request must be copied to the JCF email of the Divisional Commander, the Crime Officer and the Investigating Officer.

7.0 Policy Statement

It is the policy of the JCF that:

- 7.1 all cases of sudden or unnatural death shall be investigated promptly with professionalism, sensitivity and tact;
- 7.2 requests for port-mortem will be done in a timely manner, and
- 7.3 investigating officers shall attend post-mortem examination as scheduled

8.0 Standard Operating Procedures

The following are the procedural guidelines of the JCF that members must adhere to in the investigation of Sudden, and Unnatural Deaths:

- 8.1 Upon receipt of a report of sudden or unnatural death, the Sub-Officer of station shall immediately cause an investigation to be conducted into the circumstances relating to the death.
- 8.2 The sub-officer i/c station or the police monitor (where the call is made to the Police Emergency Communication Centre) shall direct a police team to respond to the initial report
- 8.3 All deaths are to be treated as unnatural until the contrary is proven by the Pathologist.
- 8.4 All reports of sudden and or unnatural deaths should be recorded in the **STATION DIARY** and the **SUDDEN DEATH REGISTER**.
- 8.5 Where death is sudden and of an unknown cause and there is no medical certificate forthcoming to support the report, then a post-mortem **must** be ordered.

- 8.6 Cause and manner of death should **ONLY** be concluded after the post-mortem.
- 8.7 The final cause of death must **NOT** be disclosed until after the pathologist submits the report.
- 8.8 The circumstances surrounding death, including medical history where death may be sudden should be noted by the first responder and made available to the investigator.
- 8.9 This information should be made available by the investigator to the Pathologist at or before the time of the post-mortem.
- 8.10 The exact position of the body as best as possible should be reflected in a sketch.
- 8.11 In the case of suspected murder or manslaughter, **DO NOT** remove the body until a medical doctor has completed an examination.
- 8.12 Where a medical officer is unavailable, as best as possible the body should be photographed in its original position.
- 8.13 A description of the body should be made as also the condition of the clothing.
- 8.14 At the scene of a sudden death where no medical certificate is forthcoming, all prescription drugs, over-the-counter drugs and other items appearing to be medicinal found on the scene should be preserved and treated as exhibits.
- 8.15 Position of all wounds or injuries must be noted.
- 8.16 Any visible signs of a struggle or other matters in this regard likely to prove useful in the course of the investigation must be noted.
- 8.17 Teeth, hand and fingernails should be examined, especially where signs of resistance are evident; during a struggle, the victim may have removed some form of scientific evidence from the attacker/assailant.
- 8.18 Where there is any difficulty identifying the body it should be photographed, fingerprinted and caused to be published in the Police Gazette.
- 8.19 With respect to un-identified bodies, if no relative has come forward to identify the body after compliance with 8.16, then a post-mortem should

be conducted and the body caused to be buried within **thirty (30)** days at the expense of the state.

8.20 Decomposed Bodies

8.20.1 In instances where bodies are found to be badly decomposed and no post-mortem can be performed, the police will have no need to contact the contracted funeral homes but should instead contact the local Chief Medical Officer for rural parishes or the Pathologist at the IFSLM in the case of Kingston and St Andrew for arrangements to be made for inspection of the body to confirm that the body is too decomposed for a post mortem to be carried out.

8.20.2 Thereafter, the Police will hand over the body to family members after completion of the inspection for immediate burial.

8.20.3 In cases where no family member has been identified, then burial will be at the expense of the state.

8.20.4 The Medical Officer when issuing the Medical Certificate as to the Cause of Death may write '***undetermined due to body being badly decomposed***'. This cause of death is accepted by the Registrar General's Department.

8.21 Sudden or Unnatural Death at Home

Once a call is received at the station about a sudden death at home, the following should obtain:

8.21.1 The scene should be visited by a sub-officer.

8.21.2 At the scene the first responder will determine whether the deceased:

- a) was ailing and under the care of a physician
- b) visited the doctor or hospital within the last three months
- c) had any known medical condition (s)
- d) had showed any sign of trauma or the scene reflects any sign of violence

8.21.3 The police officer at the scene will take detailed notes of observations made and information received.

8.21.4 If there is no sign of foul play, the officer will instruct the family to obtain a medical certificate showing the cause of death from the attending

physician/medical facility and to contact a funeral home of their choice. In these cases, where a post – mortem is required, the family should make the arrangements to have it done privately.

8.21.5 If the officer has reason to believe that death was not from a natural/medical cause, then the officer must contact the government contracted funeral home for that police area for the body to be collected, and make arrangements for the scene to be processed.

8.21.6 The officer must collect a body receipt from the funeral home.

8.21.7 The officer must then submit an Autopsy Requisition Form to the Pathology Unit (Legal Medicine Unit) stating the circumstances and the reason for the police investigation of such death.

8.22 IFSLM Requirements for Police Action and Treatment of Sudden Deaths

The Institute of Forensic Science and Legal Medicine IFSLM (Legal Medicine/Pathology Unit) has responsibility for conducting post-mortems and have outlined the parameters within which they will act. The police will therefore treat with all reports of sudden deaths in an expeditious manner to not only prevent unnecessary trauma on the family members of the deceased but also to prudently manage the JCF resources. The following Table outlines the police actions when dealing with the various categories of Sudden Deaths.

8.22.1 Actions required by the Police in these cases:

CATEGORY OF DEATH	REQUIRED ACTION
Suspicious death	This is a legal/medical case; Police must call the contracted funeral home and request a post mortem from the IFSLM (Forensic Laboratory
Sudden death where the deceased had no known medical condition	This is a legal/medical case; Police must call the contracted funeral home and request a post mortem from the Forensic Laboratory.
Sudden death where the deceased had a known medical condition.	This is not necessarily a legal/medical case although a medical autopsy may be required. 1. Where the police have ascertained that there is a doctor who is willing to sign the Medical Certificate of the Cause of Death, especially in the case of the aged, the police will note the name of the doctor for inclusion in the Station Diary as well as the Sudden Death Register, and allow the family to contact a funeral home of their choice.

	2. Where it is not clear whether or not there is a doctor willing to sign the Medical Certificate of Cause of Death, the police must call the contracted funeral home. Within 48 hours the police must determine whether a doctor will sign a Medical Certificate of Cause of Death in which case the body will be released to the family to be dealt with by a funeral home of their choice.
	3. If there is no doctor willing to sign a Medical Cause of Death Certificate but there is no suspicion of foul play, then the family will make arrangements for a medical autopsy to be performed. (Not by the IFSLM - Forensic Laboratory).
	4. This must be determined within 48 hours of the death or else the contracted funeral home is at liberty to charge the family the full commercial rate.
	5. If the police cause the matter to drag beyond 48 hours they will be liable for the commercial charges and strong disciplinary action will be taken.

8.21 Cases for which autopsies (Post-Mortems) will be performed – Pathology (Legal Medicine) Unit of the Forensic Laboratory

8.21.1 The following are categories of death for which post-mortems are conducted by the Legal Medicine Unit:

- a) Homicides
- b) Suicides
- c) Hanging
- d) Poisoning or suspected poisoning
- e) Prisoners or any other ward of the State
- f) Asphyxia (eg. choking or exposure to environs where victim was denied air)
- g) Sudden deaths (victims with no known medical conditions)
- h) Suspicious deaths (foul play suspected)
- i) Motor vehicle accidents
- j) Blunt force trauma (fall/crush victims)
- k) Drowning
- l) Workplace accidents

8.21.2 In all other circumstances, family members are to be instructed to call a funeral home of their choice and to get a Medical Certificate of the Cause of Death from

the attending physician or arrange a post-mortem by contacting officials in the Ministry of Health

8.22. Request for Post Mortem

- 8.22.1. Where a Post Mortem is required, the Investigator shall complete the prescribed *Autopsy Requisition Form*, and submit through his/her sub-officer/supervisor to the Administrative Officer for the respective Division
- 8.22.2 The Administrative Officer shall make a formal request to the Director of the IFSLM submitting the *Autopsy Requisition Form*.
- 8.22.3 Once the scheduled date is received the Administrative Officer shall cause the Investigator to be notified

8.23 Police actions at and after Post Mortem

- 8.23.2 The Investigator shall attend the scheduled post mortem and take detailed notes regarding the body and any pertinent observation made by the pathologist
 - 8.23.3 upon conclusion of the post-mortem, the Investigator shall ensure that the body is handed over to the Funeral Home of the relatives' choice. At no time should any member of the JCF or Rural Police instruct that any particular funeral home be contracted.
 - 8.23.4 The Investigator shall thereafter issue the Burial Order to the relatives of the deceased
 - 8.23.5 The Investigator shall submit the case file containing the medical certificate, post-mortem report and police report, along with any available statement (s) to the Clerk of Court **within 72 hours after receiving the post-mortem report** in accordance with section 9 sub section 2b of the Coroners Act.
- 8.24** The Investigator shall keep the family of the deceased informed throughout the investigation.
- 8.25 Under no circumstance must payment or gifts be solicited or accepted from family members to expedite post mortem examination or to perform any related favour or activity. Any such request will be investigated by the Inspector General, IPROB**

9.0 Legislative Authority/Guiding Principles

The police power to investigate the sudden and or unnatural death of any person in Jamaica is grounded in several legislations, the scope of which encompasses:

- a. [The Coroners Act,](#)
- b. [The Constabulary Force's Act,](#)
- c. [The Justice of the Peace Jurisdiction Act;](#)
- d. [The Registrar \(Births and Deaths\) Act;](#)

10.0 Records and Related Forms

- a. Sudden Death Report Form
- b. Autopsy Requisition Form
- c. Forensic Death Report Form
- d. Sudden Death First Responder
- e. Sudden Death Register
- f. Station Diary

11.0 Roles and Functions

The following outlines specific roles and functions:

11.1 First Responder

Verify the report of sudden or unnatural death and the circumstances under which the individual died. Take detailed notes of observations made and information received which will form the substance of their statement and report for the sudden death file.

11.2 Investigating Officer where Post-Mortem is required

The Investigating Officer shall:

- 11.2.1 upon verification of death, complete the Autopsy (Post Mortem) Requisition Form and submit through his/her Sub-Officer within 24 hours.
- 11.2.2 attend all scheduled post-mortems for cases he/she is investigating
- 11.2.3 upon conclusion of the post-mortem, ensure that the body is handed over to the Funeral Home of the relatives' choice.
- 11.2.4 issue Burial Order to the relatives of the deceased on conclusion of the post-mortem
- 11.2.5 submit the case file containing the medical certificate, post-mortem report and police report, along with any available statement (s) to the Clerk of Court within 72 hours after receiving the post-mortem report in accordance with section 9 sub section 2b of the Coroners Act.
- 11.2.6 keep the family of the deceased informed throughout the investigation.

11.3 Sub-Officer in charge of the station

It shall be the function of the sub-officer in charge of station to :

11.3.1 Submit the request for post-mortem to the Divisional Administrative Officer **within 24 hours** after notification of sudden death.

11.3.2 immediately cause an investigation into sudden and unnatural death to be made into the circumstances relating to such death and submit a written preliminary report to the divisional commander **within forty eight (48) hours** after the scene of death has been visited by the police.

Appendix 1 – Sudden Death Report Form

JCF/FW/PL/Ops/0005/2021/F01


JAMAICA CONSTABULARY FORCE

SUDDEN DEATH REPORT

DATE:.....

INFORMATION ON DECEASED

NAME OF DECEASED:.....

ADDRESS OF THE DECEASED/
LOCATION AT TIME OF DEATH:.....

.....

DATE OF DEATH	TIME OF DEATH	AGE/D.O.B.	MALE/FEMALE
.....			

NEXT OF KIN/CONTACT PERSON.....

ADDRESS.....

.....

TELEPHONE # SIGNATURE.....

INVESTIGATOR

NAME OF OFFICER:.....

REGULATION # DIVISION.....

SIGNATURE:.....

COMMENTS.....

.....

FUNERAL HOME

NAME OF FUNERAL HOME:.....

ADDRESS:.....

DATE & TIME ON RECEIPT OF BODY:.....

SIGNATURE.....

OTHER INFORMATION

NAME AND CONTACT # OF DOCTOR WHO PRONOUNCED DEATH.....

.....

NAME AND CONTACT # OF PATHOLOGIST.....

NAME OF HOSPITAL/ MORGUE.....

NAME AND ADDRESS OF PERSON REPORTING DEATH AND CONTACT #.....

BURIAL ORDER REF. # DATE.....

POLICE STATION.....

NAME OF INVESTIGATING OFFICER.....

INSTITUTE OF FORENSIC SCIENCE AND LEGAL MEDICINE – AUTOPSY REQUISITION FORM

Tel.: 876 977.0229-33 Fax: 876 977.0234 Email: autopsydrrp@gmail.com

Name (Last, First):

☐ UNIDENTIFIED

Requisition Date (year/ month/ day):

Male/Female/Unknown

Crime Reference Number:
(If applicable)

Age:

number)

Investigating Officer:
(Including rank, regulation number, contact

Date of Death (Year/Month/Day):

Contact Information:

Deceased address:
(If different from above)

Police Area/Station:

Morgue/Funeral Home:

CIRCUMSTANCES SURROUNDING DEATH

LAST SEEN ALIVE /		UNKNOWN
MONTH	DAY	TIME(HH:MM)
DISCOVERED BY		

DESCRIPTION OF THE SCENE

(Include positioning and appearance of the body; surroundings; objects of evidence; alcohol, drugs, medications, etc, at the scene)

Body was seen lying on the floor in a pool of blood inside a cook shop.

SCENE INVESTIGATION

☐PHOTOS NOT TAKEN

☐PHOTOS TAKEN

☐PHOTOS AVAILABLE AT POSTMORTEM

SOCIAL HISTORY

(Include pertinent details of living situation, house hold residents and ages, drug/alcohol history; nature of past police history (e.g theft, sex offender, violence, drugs)

KNOWN TO POLICE

☐ YES ☐ NO

MEDICAL HISTORY (Including hospitalization)

DOCKET

☐ YES

PROVIDED/ACCOMPANIED

(Must be provided when

deceased died in hospital)

INFECTIOUS DISEASE STATUS ☐ KNOWN HIV POSITIVE ☐ KNOWN HEPATITIS C POSITIVE ☐ OTHERS	FORM COMPLETED BY: SIGNATURE AND STAMP:
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Note: Autopsy order means for complete postmortem examination, besides retention, removal and examination of organs and for disposition of such as the pathologist determine

Appendix 3



FORENSIC DEATH REPORT

SERIAL NO _____

DATE _____

INFORMATION ON DECEASED

NAME OF DECEASED.....

PLACE OF DEATH.....

DATE OF DEATH	TIME OF DEATH	AGE/D.O.B	SEX-M/F
.....			

NEXT OF KIN/CONTACT PERSON.....

ADDRESS.....

TELEPHONE #..... SIGNATURE.....

INVESTIGATOR

NAME OF OFFICER:.....

REGULATION #..... DIVISION.....

SIGNATURE:..... SEAL.....

COMMENTS.....

.....

.....

FUNERAL HOME

NAME OF FUNERAL HOME.....

ADDRESS:.....

DATE & TIME ON RECEIPT OF BODY:

SIGNATURE:.....

OTHER INFORMATION

NAME AND CONTECT # OF PATHOLOGIST

DATE AND TIME OF POSTMORTEM EXAMINATION.....

PLACE OF POSTMORTEM EXAMINATION.....

SIGNATURE OF THE DOCTOR.....



SUDDEN DEATH FIRST RESPONDER FORM

Sudden Death Investigation Report Face Sheet – *Death.....a Medical Facility*

DEMOGRAPHIC DATA	CIRCUMSTANCES OF DEATH
First Name:_____ Last Name:_____ Alias:_____ ☐ Identity Undetermined Sex: ☐ Male ☐ Female ☐ Undetermined Age at death:_____ ☐ Actual ☐ Estimated Date of birth: Year_____Month_____Day_____ Date of death: Year_____Month_____Day_____ ☐ Occurred on date body discovered ☐ Occurred on date before body discovered Usual address: Street and Apt# or Landmark: _____ _____ Parish:_____ City and country if not usually resident in Jamaica:_____ Place of death/where body discovered: _____ _____ POST MORTEM INFORMATION Date post mortem conducted: Year_____Month_____Day_____ Name of Pathologist: _____ Date reported:_____ Name of Investigator:_____	Nature of death ☐ Violent injury: Specify type of weapon used: _____ Inflicted by: ☐ Self ☐ Other identified person(s) (specify) _____ _____ _____ ☐ Other unidentified person Other injury: ☐ Motor vehicle accident: ☐ Driver ☐ River ☐ Pedestrian ☐ Drowning: ☐ at sea ☐ River ☐ Other ☐ House fire ☐ Other accidental cause (specify) _____ ☐ Natural causes (no signs of injury noted) ☐ Has a known medical condition ☐ Has a usual medical provider Name of doctor:_____ ☐ Doctor’s name not known ☐ Sudden unexpected death, no medical provider _____ Summary: ☐ Family able to get medical certificate ☐ Coroner’s case for post mortem Place PM done:_____ Date post mortem report received: Year_____Month_____Day_____ Case file completed: ☐ No ☐ Yes

Appendix 5 – Specimen of Headings for Sudden Death Register

Cons No	Date and Time of Report	Name and Address of person Reporting	How Reported	Name and Address of Deceased	Details of Report	Name and Rank of Investigating Officer	Brief Report of Preliminary Investigation	Date Post Mortem Received	Date of Inquest	Cause of Death	Remarks